

D-Link R15 AX1500 Eagle PRO AI Wi-Fi 6 Router

An affordable Wi-Fi 6 router

The D-Link AX1500 Eagle Pro Smart Router R15 is all about democratising Wi-Fi 6. It's geared towards bringing the latest wireless technology to the masses by pricing the router at a very attractive price point. However, does that mean that a lot of corners were cut? Let's find out.

SPECIFICATIONS

While this is a Wi-Fi 6 router on a budget, D-Link goes the extra mile by throwing in a couple of interesting AI features. So not only do folks get to jump onto the latest Wi-Fi 6 bandwagon but they can also talk to Amazon Alexa or Google Assistant and control the router.

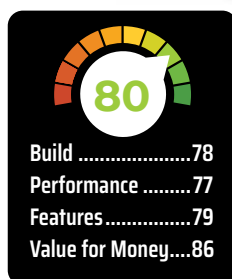
So what has D-Link chosen for their platform?

Apparently, a Realtek RTL8198D does most of the thinking. The RTL8198D comes with an inbuilt high-power amplifier and supports the EasyMesh feature. This means that if your existing router supports EasyMesh, then you can use the two devices to build a mesh network. The RTL8198D is also a low-power chip and it supports high throughput. So it can operate at low voltage levels while ensuring high bandwidth on all the bands.

BUILD QUALITY

The router is pretty lightweight and looks very similar to the D-Link EXO X1560 router but that ends with the external body. On the inside, the two are quite distinct. The EXO X1560 is based on a Broadcom BCM6750 solution whereas the R15 is based on the Realtek RTL8198D solution. The Realtek solution comes at a much lower price point and offers a

₹2,799



very similar set of features. Along with the RTL8198D, there is a Realtek RT8192FR and a Realtek RT8832AR. The former is what handles the 2.4 GHz band and the latter handles the 5 GHz band. Both support a 2x2:2 configuration so handling

multiple devices on both streams isn't an issue. Also, this combination of the RTL8198D + RTL8192FR + RTL8832AR is an Wi-Fi 6 solution from Realtek with AI QoS features that work even without using any Deep Packet Inspection. So you've got pretty good hardware with AI features baked into the platform, which makes it a much more stable platform compared to something that would have primarily used the firmware to provide the AI features.

On the rear, we see that the R15 has 1x WAN and 3x LAN Gigabit ports. Neither routers have any USB ports and they have the same set of antennae. Essentially, the R15 has a similar feature set at a lower price point than the X1560.

PERFORMANCE

It's no secret that Broadcom's solutions are usually a little pricier than similar Realtek solutions but they're also better

performers. Since we still have the numbers from the time we reviewed the DIR-X1560, this would be a great comparison between the two close competitors.

In our Zone 1 tests where the routers are placed in close proximity, the two routers i.e. the DIR R15 and the DIR-X1560 perform in a very similar manner. But as we move to Zone 2 which is a few metres away from the base station, we see the DIR-X1560 perform slightly better than the R15. The R15 has a throughput ranging in the low 20s whereas the X1560 scores around 40 MBps.

Switching to 5 GHz brings about a much wider performance gap between the two routers. The R15 clocks in at about 600 MBps whereas the DIR-X1560 manages to get an additional 100 MBps over the R15 as it hovers in the lower 700s. This is when the two routers are in close proximity to the base station. As we move to Zone 2, both routers drop to about 200 MBps but the R15 is consistently lesser than the DIR-X1560 in terms of throughput.

In our gaming tests, we see the two routers performing the same without any issues whatsoever.

VERDICT

D-Link makes two great Wi-Fi routers available at very affordable price points. One is a Broadcom solution priced around Rs. 3600 and the Realtek one around Rs. 2799 which is much cheaper. Honestly, the performance difference between the two more or less justifies the performance gap between them as well, so it really comes down to how much you'd want to spend. We'd recommend the X1560 if you want an extra LAN port and Link Aggregation but if you want a more polished app, then the R15 is a better candidate.

—Mithun Mohandas

SPECIFICATIONS

Model: R15 | Wi-Fi: 802.11ax | LAN: 3x 1 GbE | WAN: 1x GbE | SoC: RTL8198D | WLAN: RTL8192 + RTX8832 | Dimensions: 25.2 x 16.6 x 19.4 cms | Weight: 300 kg | Warranty: 3 - years.

CONTACT

D-Link (India) Ltd. | Phone: +1800-233-3999 | Email: Divya.Shetty@in.dlink.com | Website: in.dlink.com